The great fear which Bolshevism could incite in Britain was demonstrated in 1924 by the case of the Zinoviev Letter. The ‘greatest Red Scare in British political history’ was precipitated by the publication in British newspapers of a letter ostensibly written by Zinoviev to the British Communist party instructing them to prepare for the coming of a revolution in Britain.[3] The publication happened just four days before the general election of 29 October 1924 and is generally seen as the reason for the Conservatives’ victory in the polls that month.[4] The Soviet government denied authorship of the letter but it was not until 1999 that the truth of the matter was revealed when it was shown that the letter was a forgery, written most probably by White Russians in Berlin in an attempt to disturb the relationship between Britain and Russia.[5] How far the Foreign Office of the time suspected the authenticity of the letter remains unknown – the years after the Russian revolution saw a veritable avalanche of documents of dubious origin making their way into Britain, all purporting to provide information on the Bolshevik regime, or indeed claiming to be written by the Soviet government itself. The note of 1921, for example, which Curzon had presented to Moscow detailing Bolshevik transgressions of the trade agreement had been proven to be based on bad intelligence. The important point is that in 1924 the fear and suspicion which Soviet Russia could ignite amongst the British public was enough to apparently influence a general election. If Curzon wanted support for his Persian plans, using Bolshevism to scare his colleagues into action appeared a good idea.

In the end Curzon’s scaremongering actually did not matter. For the likes of Montagu, it was financial considerations which persuaded him to support the creation of the Persian agreement. But Curzon’s use of anti-Bolshevik rhetoric for his own means does go some way to explaining some of his behaviour towards Persia after 1919. Given his doomsday warnings in 1918, Curzon appeared very complacent in 1920 when discussing the potential for a Bolshevik invasion of Persia. In the months that followed the Enzeli landings, as Soviet Russia gradually increased its presence within that country, Curzon remained relatively placid. If he had truly been that concerned about the threat which Bolshevism posed to Persia and to South Asia at large, one would have expected greater agitation from the foreign secretary. Instead, Curzon wanted to create the Anglo-Persian agreement in order to make his mark on the region and extend Britain’s imperial